

A Helping Hand to the Family: Building Confidence through Entrepreneurship and Financial Literacy

Becoming financially independent and being able to contribute to the family is a dream for many women out there, but not every woman gets the required opportunity to fulfill the dream. Suman Ji from **Hamirpur, Himachal Pradesh** is one such woman who aspired to become an earning member of the family to contribute to the family in terms of finances as well apart from fulfilling the household responsibilities. For her, entrepreneurship was not just about income, it was more about becoming financially independent and being able to create opportunities for other women. Having studied till class 10, she always had an interest in knitting and stitching, but before getting married, her work was limited to the local neighbourhood only. However after the marriage she began seeing this skill as a business opportunity and focussed on its expansion so as to reach out to a larger customer base.



She joined the self help group formally in 2021 while simultaneously starting her journey of entrepreneurship in the month of November of the same year. Along with her business of knitting and stitching, she decided to diversify her income by doing dairy farming to sell milk and also learnt to prepare badiya for sale. Although her husband works as a driver and earns enough to run a family adequately, she aspired to become a helping hand for him, to share the responsibilities of the family and become financially independent. This aspiration laid the foundation of her entrepreneurial journey.

Starting a business and running it successfully is never an easy task to achieve, same was the case with her as when she started, one of the challenges she encountered was the lack of trust amongst people regarding the purity and quality of her products. People hesitated to purchase them from her, however with continuous effort and dedication she built credibility and overcame this challenge and started making a good amount of sales. A satisfied customer is always having the potential to recommend the same product to others, so her business gained acceptance and recognition.

Earlier she used to deliver the products to the local nearby area only, but after joining the SHG she learnt about the significance of online marketing and the mechanism of digital platforms such as Whatsapp and instagram business to promote the products online and take them out to a larger customer base. This made her business go beyond the localities and get more recognition.

The Training of Financial and Digital literacy strengthened her with the adequate support required in terms of systematic record keeping. It made her realize the importance of maintaining proper and well documented records to make sound financial decisions. The sessions on the cashbook and balancesheet were very much valuable for her. She now regularly maintains her financial records and finds it extremely useful, especially because block offices require the well documented financial records for official purposes.

Another significant area in which the training helped her was the UPI based digital payment system, which made the transactions faster and safer for herself and her customers. Apart from this she was happy and excited to know about ONDC as a digital marketplace. She wishes to learn more about ONDC to enable herself to do business on it. Her excitement to learn more about financial and digital literacy reflects her commitment to grow her business to a sky high level.

Today, Suman Ji has become an inspiration for all other women who want to pursue entrepreneurship but are not confident enough to initiate. Whenever she meets such women, she encourages them to step forward, learn new skills, join SHGs and explore entrepreneurship. Her story represents how one's determination and commitment can be an example for many others.